

our Mexican Seaboard stock.

Had we held the shares we already owned and bought more in 1931, we could have acquired control of the company at a fantastic bargain price. Mexican Seaboard common's subsequent performance proved that this would have been a major financial coup—and that I would have made millions.

I pulled my worst boner in 1932. I was interested in obtaining an oil concession in Iraq, where geological surveys and exploration operations indicated the presence of vast oil deposits beneath the hell-hot desert sands. My representative, conducting negotiations with Iraqi government officials in Baghdad, reported that a tempting concession was available for a price that could be tallied in tens of thousands of dollars. Just then, the U.S. crude-oil price broke; East Texas crude plummeted to ten cents a barrel—and the petroleum industry was in a panic. Fearing to risk capital outlays under those circumstances, I ordered my agent in Baghdad to halt all negotiations.

The next time I had an opportunity to buy a Middle Eastern oil concession, in 1949, I seized it unhesitatingly.

Conditions were far different than they had been 17 years earlier, however. In 1949, I had to pay \$12,500,000 in cash upon signing the concession agreement!

Bad as they were, it would be solacing to think these were my only errors, but I made many others and will

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doubtless make many more. As I've said before, businessmen are no exceptions to the rule that everyone makes mistakes. But personal experience and observation have taught me that most mistakes made by businessmen and executives fall into certain broad, though readily definable, categories.